frisson. Experiencing all these when Vikas shows the fire in its belly, I thought, would be an emotional upheaval for me.

But none of this happened. I managed to stay put in the open as the countdown was being announced through a public address system. During the first sixty seconds of the firing, I was in a trance, not realizing that the ignition happened perfectly and Vikas was going through the rituals as expected. Then I saw the metal turning red hot and the flame a steady blast. At ninety seconds, I relaxed. After the hundredth second, it was an interplay of anticipation and apprehension. At the end of 180 seconds, when the firing ended, there was deadpan silence. And then a roar of applause and cheers by the team that now poured out of the control room and instrumentation room.

Among the revelers was Kanwal Grover, the long-time friend of Indian space science. Once it sank in, colleagues had different reactions. Sadasivam said he felt as if the test was over in no time; Narendranath said it was an eternity for him. Anandan and Sukumaran Nair were speechless. I shook Nair. All he could utter was, 'Sir, sir…' He had tears in his eyes.

I asked the SEP scientists if I could place a call to India. They obliged. When the line crackled to life, I heard the voice 'Rao speaking.'

I told the ISRO chairman that the test has been a textbook success.

'Great, Nambi,' Rao said. 'Give every Frenchman there a treat. And send us some photographs.'

I informed the ISRO Technical Liaison Unit (ITLV) attached to the Indian Consulate in Paris. Mathur, the officer, asked something I should have asked Rao, but forgot in the euphoria, 'Who would foot the bill for the party?'

The Government of India's budget for the Vikas test had definitely not taken into account the need for uncorking a bottle of champagne. Mathur checked with the ambassador who knew little about ISRO, and nothing about the significance of the Vikas test. When everyone was staring at each other, all wondering what to do, there came our perennial saviour, Kanwal Grover.